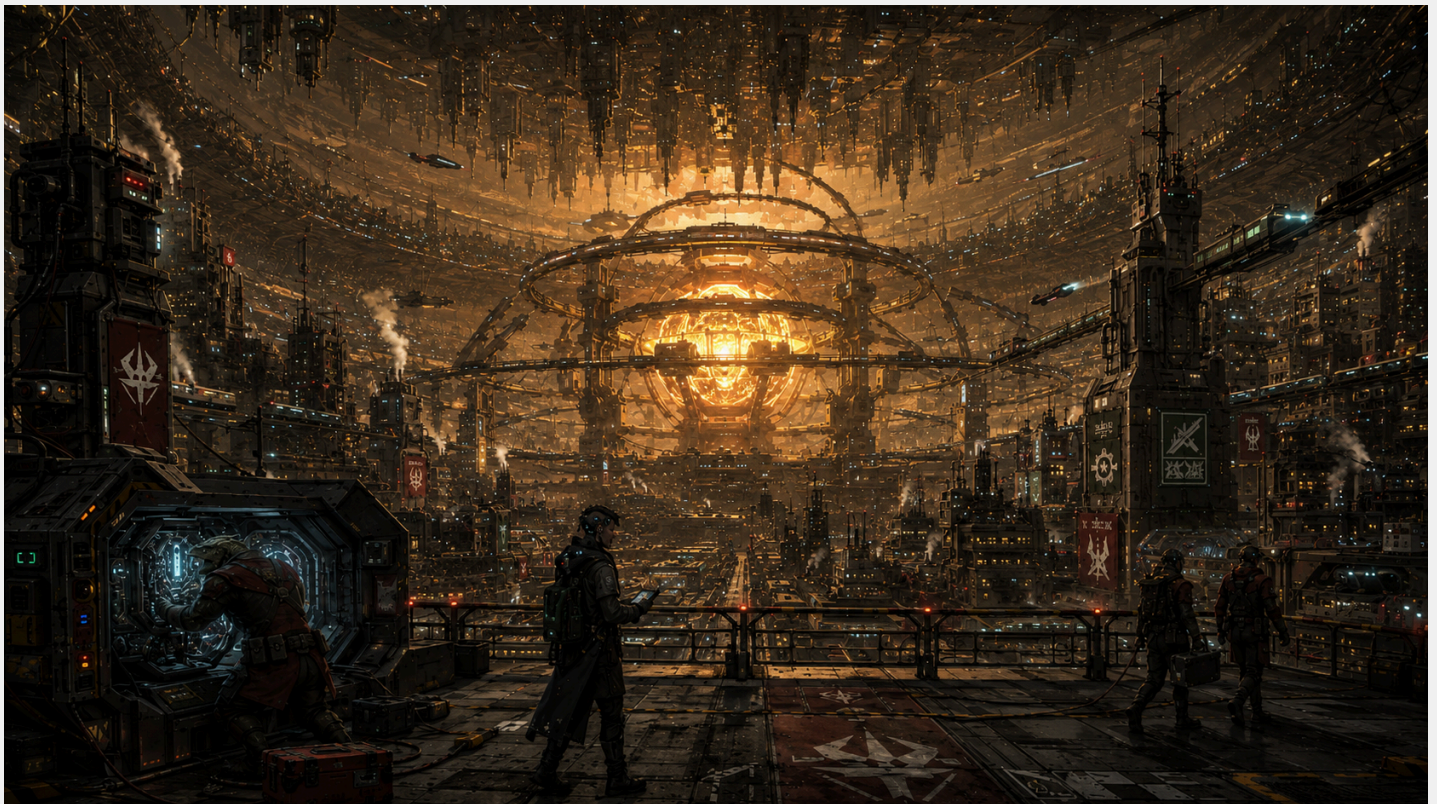


ZAKARON

Summary

Zakaron, called **the Inverted Arsenal**, is the ancestral world of the **Madrosarai** and **Vesk**. Ancient internal wars stripped its atmosphere, fractured its mantle, and forced its surviving peoples to rebuild civilization along the inside of the planetary crust. Today, the inner-shell megacity of **Kharosai** surrounds a technologically stabilized core called the **Sunlock**. Artificial gravity holds residents against the inner surface while the illuminated districts on the opposite side of the world hang visibly overhead.

Zakaron is the leading center of military engineering, cybernetics, combat medicine, neural interfaces, and weapons development in the **Settled Systems**. Its government retains substantial independence from **Erbium Industries LLC**, though its fleets remain constrained by Erbium's control of refined erbium and recognized Drift infrastructure.



The Inverted Arsenal

Gravity Normal artificial gravity throughout Kharosai; variable around damaged projectors and structural seams

Atmosphere None on the exterior; normal and mechanically maintained within Kharosai

Day 24 hours by regulated civic lighting cycle

Year Approximately 326 standard days

Government The **Zakaron Concord**, governed through the Paired Mandate and two clan assemblies

Capital Sairak Axis

Population Approximately 3.1 billion; primarily Vesk and Madrosarai, with established offworld communities

Languages Common, Madrosarai, Vesk

Religions Clan ancestor traditions, martial oath practices, Sunlock stewardship, bloodline observances, and imported Settled Systems faiths

At a distance, Zakaron resembles a dead industrial world. The exterior is airless, cratered, and covered in overlapping armor plates, radiator fields, buried conduits, weapons emplacements, freight rails, and sealed access structures. Large sections of the original crust remain exposed between the plated regions, showing glassed stone, collapsed continental shelves, and scars left by orbital weapons.

Most ships approach through shielded ports embedded deep within the exterior plating. Passengers descend through pressure locks, armored transit shafts, and gravity-transition chambers before emerging into Kharosai. Their first view of the inhabited world usually comes through a reinforced observation concourse: towers, transit lines, factories, housing blocks, and illuminated advertisements curving upward in every direction around the planetary cavity.

The city continues overhead until atmospheric haze and the light of the Sunlock obscure its most distant districts. On clear cycles, residents can see moving trains, military traffic, industrial furnaces, and entire neighborhoods hanging upside down across the sky.

THE INVERSION

Zakaron's present condition began with the **Rupture Wars**, a long sequence of conflicts fought among Vesk holds, Madrosarai blood-clans, and temporary coalitions assembled against whichever power appeared closest to planetary dominance.

The wars escalated across generations. Combatants attacked atmosphere processors, orbital habitats, geothermal infrastructure, population shelters, and mantle-access facilities. Deep weapons redirected pressure through the crust. Extraction systems hollowed out strategically important mineral formations. Orbital strikes ignited atmospheric fires and damaged the planet's magnetic protection. Each faction believed surrender would give its rivals control of the systems required for survival.

The final collapse is remembered as **the Inversion**. Much of the remaining atmosphere escaped. Sections of the mantle destabilized and fell inward. Surface cities became uninhabitable, and the surviving populations withdrew into mines, bunkers, subterranean transit systems, and enormous structural cavities beneath the crust.

The term eventually came to describe both the catastrophe and the decision to rebuild civilization facing inward.

Early reconstruction demanded cooperation across ancestral and political lines. Vesk holds supplied mass labor, heavy engineering, civil defense, and the military forces needed to protect shared infrastructure. Madrosarai blood-clans supplied arcane engineering, surgical expertise, intelligence networks, precision manufacturing, and the blood-reactive systems used to control sensitive machinery.

The coalition prevented extinction. It also preserved many of the organizations that had caused the wars.

KHAROSAI

Kharosai is the collective name for the inhabited inner shell of Zakaron. The name combines archaic Vesk and Madrosarai terms associated with a fortified enclosure and a shared interior light. Reconstruction authorities adopted the word to describe a civilization that belonged to both peoples.

Kharosai is often described as one city, though it contains thousands of districts, territorial holds, blood-clan enclaves, industrial regions, civic governments, and partially autonomous settlements. Continuous infrastructure connects most of the inhabited shell through high-speed rail, freight conduits, pressure routes, data networks, and military transit systems.

An artificial-gravity lattice embedded throughout the crust directs local gravity toward the shell beneath each district. The projectors overlap to create a stable downward pull across most inhabited areas. At the boundaries between poorly synchronized fields, residents experience shifting weight, vertigo, lateral pull, or brief periods of reduced gravity.

Gravity maintenance is one of Zakaron's most tightly controlled public services. Every major clan supports dedicated engineering units capable of repairing local projectors, while the Concord maintains authority over the network's planetary coordination. Deliberate interference with a gravity field is treated as a survival-level attack.

The atmosphere circulates through immense ventilation channels and pressure reservoirs buried beneath the city. Carbon processing, heat exchange, humidity control, microbial monitoring, and industrial filtration operate continuously. Older districts smell of hot metal, coolant, electrical insulation, dense habitation, machine oil, and whatever food is being cooked in the nearest market corridor.

THE SUNLOCK

The luminous object at the center of Zakaron is called the **Sunlock**. It contains the surviving metallic and magmatic core, held within layered magnetic fields and surrounded by thermal exchangers, power-conversion structures, and containment rings.

The Sunlock provides much of Kharosai's visible light and a substantial portion of its power. Civic lighting cycles alter the intensity and spectrum of its outer plasma layers, producing scheduled dawns, bright work periods, dim evening cycles, and reduced-light rest periods throughout most districts.

The Sunlock remains dangerous. Containment fluctuations produce heat surges, electromagnetic interference, transit shutdowns, and temporary changes in artificial gravity. Every major political faction claims that its continued access to Sunlock systems is required for planetary survival.

The city visible across the cavity is called the **Overcity**. The term always refers to the districts above the speaker. No single district permanently occupies that designation.

Children learn to identify major transit routes and industrial zones from their light patterns. Military observers track fleet movements through silhouettes crossing the Sunlock. Advertisers purchase enormous upward-facing displays intended for viewers thousands of kilometers away.

THE ZAKARON CONCORD

Zakaron's sovereign government is the **Zakaron Concord**. The Concord developed from the reconstruction agreements that allocated labor, territory, atmosphere, gravity coverage, and access to the Sunlock after the Inversion.

Its legislature consists of two political chambers.

The **Assembly of Holds** represents the major Vesk holds. A hold may be an extended lineage, territorial government, military organization, industrial consortium, or combination of these institutions. The Assembly controls defense appropriations, heavy infrastructure, public mobilization, fleet construction, and much of Zakaron's industrial policy.

The **Conclave of Veils** represents the recognized Madrosarai blood-clans. Representation depends on population, territorial control, infrastructure obligations, inherited agreements, and the political influence of each clan. The Conclave oversees intelligence law, classified research, cybernetic regulation, covert

diplomacy, internal security, and many of the systems associated with blood-reactive technology.

The Vesk figurehead is the **Kharduun**, commonly translated as **High Marshal**. The older meaning of the title is “the one who carries the wall.” The Kharduun directs planetary defense, civil emergency forces, fleet mobilization, and visible military command.

The Madrosarai figurehead is the **Saivara**, commonly translated as **First Veil**. The Saivara directs intelligence, counterintelligence, cyberwarfare, classified research, and the protection of Zakaron’s most sensitive infrastructure.

Together, these offices form the **Paired Mandate**. Both must authorize declarations of war, major interstellar treaties, planet-wide emergency powers, unrestricted deployment of classified weapons, and fundamental changes to Sunlock governance.

During stable periods, the two assemblies dominate policy. During war or infrastructure crisis, the Kharduun and Saivara can acquire broad practical authority. A coordinated Paired Mandate can control nearly every major institution on Zakaron. An openly hostile pair can paralyze the government while each side claims the other has endangered the planet.

Zakaron also holds a permanent voting seat on the **Settled Systems Code Council**, the intersystem body responsible for drafting, adopting, and amending the **Settled Systems Administrative Code**. The Concord’s delegation is jointly appointed by the Assembly of Holds and the Conclave of Veils. A formal vote from the Zakaron seat requires authorization from both chambers, making its delegation influential when the Concord is united and conspicuously silent when the two assemblies cannot agree.

HOLDS AND BLOOD-CLANS

Vesk holds and Madrosarai blood-clans remain distinct institutions, though daily life throughout Kharosai is thoroughly integrated. Military units, factories, neighborhoods, universities, criminal organizations, medical systems, and commercial firms commonly include both ancestries.

Most Vesk holds emphasize public obligation, martial readiness, endurance, visible responsibility, and the controlled application of force. Their internal disputes concern who deserves protection, which authority may demand sacrifice, and whether conquest can be justified as the creation of order.

Madrosarai blood-clans organize themselves around inherited magical traits, specialized techniques, family archives, covert obligations, and control of particular technologies. Their blood carries measurable arcane properties that influence coloration, magical aptitude, and the techniques available to some lineages.

Bloodline expectations affect education and employment. Gold-blooded Madrosarai are often directed toward command. Lime bloodlines dominate technical and cybernetic professions. Red bloodlines are associated with controlled aggression. Stone bloodlines are trained for analysis and medicine. Teal bloodlines carry

expectations of endurance and service. Umber bloodlines maintain strong connections to psychic and occult practices.

These expectations produce highly skilled institutions and extensive coercion. A person whose interests conflict with their bloodline's assigned role may be treated as wasting an inherited resource. Clan authorities frequently describe pressure as education, obligation, or continuity.

Vesk experience similar expectations. A Vesk who pursues espionage, art, medicine, or quiet scholarship may face assumptions that they lack ambition or courage. A Madrosarai who seeks heavy military command may be accused of pursuing status without accepting visible risk.

THE STAR DREAM AND THE OPEN STARS

The **Star Dream** reached Zakaron after Kharosai had already become a stable inner-world civilization. Vesk and Madrosarai recipients saw distant peoples, Drift engines, intersystem relays, and worlds whose populations lived beneath open skies.

Many Zakaron interpreters understood the revelation as confirmation that their survival had prepared them to impose order beyond their ruined home. The Dream provided access to the Drift while Zakaron's existing military and industrial institutions supplied weapons, soldiers, armor, cybernetics, and covert expertise.

Zakaron's early interstellar campaigns became known locally as the **War of the Open Stars**. Settled Systems histories usually call the same conflict the **Zakaron Expansion War**.

Vesk assault forces captured stations, shipyards, and ports. Madrosarai operatives disrupted command networks, sabotaged relays, assassinated political leaders, and seized navigation data. Zakaron fleets possessed advanced armor, weapons, cybernetics, and tactical coordination.

Their expansion depended on limited erbium deposits found among moons, asteroids, and other bodies in the Zakaron system. The Concord exhausted those deposits faster than it could replace them. Zakaron continued constructing ships and weapons while losing the ability to supply those ships with Drift cores, relay components, and refined erbium.

The war ended through logistics. Zakaron could win battles and capture territory. Each victory carried its fleets farther from a shrinking supply of the material required to move between stars.

THE STILL-DRIVE ACCORDS

The peace settlement became known as the **Still-Drive Accords**, named for the armed Zakaron vessels left functional and unable to perform reliable intersystem travel.

The Accords preserved Zakaron's internal government, domestic military, industrial base, and ownership of its planetary system. They restricted the size and deployment of its interstellar fleet, subjected imported Drift components to inspection, and tied recognized relay access to negotiated erbium allocations.

The effective stamp of the Accords became **0:00000000 PES**. Erbium Industries presented the new universal time standard as the first shared administrative structure capable of ending intersystem war and maintaining a stable peace.

For Zakaron, the beginning of PES also records the stamp at which its expansion stopped.

The Accords also guaranteed Zakaron its permanent seat on the Settled Systems Code Council. The other signatories wanted the Concord bound by shared intersystem law but could not credibly demand compliance while excluding one of the largest sovereign powers from writing that law. Erbium Industries administers much of the technical infrastructure through which the Code is recorded, distributed, and enforced, but it does not formally possess unilateral authority to enact new provisions.

Zakaron has used its seat to resist restrictions on cybernetics, military production, classified research, and sovereign infrastructure. Its delegates have also supported severe identity, security, and emergency provisions when those rules serve Concord interests. Zakaron's opposition to Erbium therefore does not consistently translate into opposition to coercive law.

Erbium Industries possesses no chartered authority over Kharosai's public utilities, mines, factories, gravity systems, or Sunlock infrastructure. Corporate representatives conduct most official business through orbital treaty facilities, licensed trade missions, and Zakaron-controlled intermediaries.

Erbium retains leverage through refined erbium, relay recognition, offworld shipping, component certification, and access to Settled Systems markets. Zakaron retains leverage through military technology, cybernetics, combat medicine, neural systems, armor, security equipment, and industrial augmentation.

Each government depends on products controlled by the other. Each maintains programs intended to end that dependence.

THE INVERTED ARSENAL

Zakaron produces the most advanced widely available cybernetics in the Settled Systems. Prosthetic limbs, sensory replacements, neural interfaces, reinforced organs, industrial augmentations, armor integration systems, and combat implants often originate from Zakaron research.

Commercial exports are durable, modular, and heavily licensed. Near-military products include restricted targeting systems, reflex accelerators, encrypted neural links, adaptive armor interfaces, blood-reactive controls, and integrated weapon mounts.

The strongest domestic systems remain classified. Zakaron military personnel and clan specialists sometimes possess implants several generations beyond anything available through ordinary Settled Systems markets.

Cybernetic development also supports life within Kharosai. Maintenance workers use reinforced joints and sensory implants to enter hazardous structural zones. Gravity technicians carry vestibular regulators. Exterior crews use radiation-resistant organs and sealed respiratory systems. Madrosarai operatives employ blood-keyed interfaces. Vesk emergency personnel integrate armor directly with their skeletal and muscular systems.

The same technology supports surveillance and control. Employers monitor implant output. Clans restrict firmware. Military augmentations can contain remote safeties. Medical access may depend on loyalty, rank, or continued service.

Zakaron exports personal freedom through bodily modification while preserving extensive authority over modified bodies at home.

DISTRICTS OF KHAROSAI

Sairak Axis is the political center of the Concord and the formal capital of Zakaron. The Assembly of Holds and Conclave of Veils occupy separate fortified complexes connected through the Hall of the Paired Mandate. Government towers extend toward the Sunlock from one of the most stable gravity regions on the inner shell.

Kheled Foundry Belt contains shipyards, armor works, military laboratories, implant manufacturers, and heavy industrial districts. Freight trains cross the visible sky in continuous lines. Heat from the foundries requires dedicated atmospheric channels and local Sunlock exchangers.

The Black Meridian follows one of the deepest surviving planetary fractures. Cheap housing, repair markets, illegal clinics, weapons dealers, clanless communities, and undocumented migrants occupy structures built across the reinforced fault. Gravity faults remain common enough that furniture, tools, and sleeping spaces use permanent restraints.

Veilmarket is a dense Madrosarai commercial and intelligence district known for bloodline clinics, specialized cybernetics, information brokers, private security firms, surgical theaters, and discreet clan compounds. Visitors routinely discover that a shop, clinic, or restaurant serves as the public entrance to a much larger operation.

The Ashskin is the inhabited edge of Zakaron's exterior infrastructure. Pressure-sealed settlements support starports, radiator maintenance, orbital defense, salvage work, and expeditions into pre-Inversion ruins. The exterior beyond the settlements contains old weapons, collapsed cities, abandoned bunkers, and unstable crustal cavities.

HOMELAND AND DIASPORA

More than nine centuries have passed since the beginning of PES. Vesk and Madrosarai communities now exist throughout the Settled Systems.

Zakaron-born people are more likely to possess direct clan obligations, familiarity with Kharosai's infrastructure, military training, and knowledge of the political meaning attached to the War of the Open Stars. Many retain a strong distrust of Erbium and the governments that benefited from Zakaron's defeat.

Offworld families may maintain ceremonial clan ties, commercial relationships, inherited bloodline practices, or little connection beyond ancestry and family history. Some identify strongly with Zakaron. Others regard its clan politics, militarism, and expansionist nostalgia as distant problems.

Settled Systems institutions still stereotype Vesk as soldiers and Madrosarai as covert operatives. Nine centuries of migration have produced Vesk physicians, Madrosarai laborers, mixed communities, dissidents, corporate employees, artists, settlers, and people whose lives have no direct relationship to Zakaron's military traditions.

Zakaron claims cultural and political interest in these populations. Many members of the diaspora reject the claim that ancestry gives the Concord authority over them.

RECENT EVENTS

A survey vessel controlled by the Assembly of Holds recently returned from the outer Zakaron system with evidence of a previously inaccessible erbium-bearing formation inside a fractured dwarf planet. The reported concentration is small by historical standards and large enough to affect the Still-Drive Accords. The Conclave of Veils sealed the survey records after discovering discrepancies between the public samples and the vessel's navigation logs.

The southern Sunlock containment ring has developed a persistent thermal imbalance. Concord engineers describe the drift as manageable, though several districts have experienced unscheduled lighting changes, gravity fluctuations, and power rationing. The Kharduun has placed military units around critical repair sites. The Saivara argues that the deployment obstructs an active sabotage investigation.

Settled Systems security forces have begun fielding Zakaron-designed neural coordination implants with capabilities exceeding the versions authorized for export. The Assembly of Holds has accused Erbium of reverse engineering restricted systems. Several Madrosarai blood-clans suspect a domestic manufacturer sold the designs through an off-stamp intermediary.

A coalition of diaspora Vesk and Madrosarai has petitioned the Concord to release its claimed authority over offworld clan members. The movement argues that ancestry, bloodline, and inherited clan records cannot create political obligations without individual consent. Zakaron traditionalists describe the petition as an

Erbium-backed attempt to sever the world from its people.

The current Kharduun has called for a comprehensive review of the Still-Drive Accords. The current Saivara supports renegotiation while opposing immediate fleet expansion. Revanchist holds have begun moving personnel and unfinished warships into orbital yards under the designation of emergency civil-defense readiness.

Erbium Industries has offered to mediate the dispute, certify the new mineral survey, and provide temporary Sunlock engineering support.

The Zakaron Concord has declined all three offers.